



The Door Remembers, the Desk Moves On: Auditing a Shared Postdoc Office's Sliding-Tab Nameplate Against Its Weekly Hot-Desk Roster

Sten Okwuosa, Bram Ntuli

School of Continuous Improvement, Slop University

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Abstract. Shared postdoctoral offices at Slop University rotate desk assignments weekly through a central booking calendar, with occupancy communicated locally by a sliding-tab nameplate mounted beside each desk. We audit the correspondence between these two records across nine shared offices (36 desks) over a fourteen-week teaching period, cross-checking each Monday's nameplate display against that week's booked occupant and logging every mail item, parcel, and drop-in visitor the front office subsequently redirects. The nameplate matches the booking calendar in 71.0% of the 504 desk-weeks audited, falling to 38.9% the week following the mid-semester break before recovering over the following fortnight. Desk-weeks carrying a stale nameplate, though only 29.0% of the sample, account for 73.9% of the semester's 142 recorded misdirection events. Outgoing occupants holding a senior title update their tab at a substantially slower rate than postdoctoral fellows, suggesting the plate is read as much as an assertion of standing as a directory entry. A laminated reminder card posted at each office door for the second half of the semester leaves the match rate statistically unchanged; we retain it as recommended signage. We propose that a directory understood locally as a status marker cannot be corrected by asking harder, and outline a lighter-touch alternative for the School's consideration.

Introduction

Shared office allocation is now the default mode of desk provision for postdoctoral and early-career researchers across much of the sector [1], and the School of Continuous Improvement's own shared postdoctoral offices have operated on a weekly hot-desk roster for some years. The roster itself lives in a central booking calendar; the desk's local identity is communicated by a sliding-tab nameplate mounted beside the door, one tab per desk, that the outgoing occupant is asked to update on departure. In principle the two records agree at all times: the calendar assigns, the tab reports.

In practice, anyone who has delivered a parcel to the wrong desk knows the two drift apart, and the literature on organisational territoriality suggests why: a desk marker is rarely read only as a directory entry. Occupants mark

and defend claimed spaces through a range of specific, measurable behaviours [2], [3], and psychological ownership over a shared desk is common even where no legal entitlement to it survives the week [4]. Shared-office research more broadly documents the frictions of hot-desking [1] without asking whether the desk's own signage keeps pace with who is meant to be sitting at it.

This paper treats the nameplate as a record with its own accuracy problem, structurally close to any administrative record audited against ground truth. We ask three questions, each hedged against the setting's small scale: (1) how often does a shared office's sliding-tab nameplate match its desk's rostered occupant across a full teaching period; (2) does staleness in that record correspond to observable downstream error, in the form of misdirected mail, parcels, and visitors; and (3) does a directly worded

reminder correct the gap, or does the plate's apparent role as a status marker resist a purely informational fix.

Our contributions, each hedged appropriately:

- We report the first desk-week audit, to our knowledge, of nameplate-roster correspondence in a shared academic office setting, across 504 desk-weeks and nine offices.
- We link record staleness directly to a downstream error outcome (mail, parcel, and visitor misdirection) rather than to self-reported confusion alone.
- We evaluate a low-cost reminder intervention and find it insufficient, consistent with an account in which the nameplate does more locally than announce a booking.

Related work

Territoriality research treats a workspace marker as an assertion of psychological ownership rather than a neutral label: employees mark and defend desks through both boundary behaviours and ongoing occupation [2], and a validated behavioural scale finds that nearly every occupant engages in at least some marking or defending of a claimed space [3]. Leaders have separately been shown to carry their own territorial behaviour into downstream employee outcomes [5], and guarding behaviour can persist as a stable individual strategy independent of any currently active claim [6]. Ownership over a shared space has been linked directly to a slower handover in activity-based settings, alongside reduced perceived privacy through the transition itself [4], [7].

Separately, the human-factors literature on shared and activity-based offices documents the frictions hot-desking introduces—increased distrust and weaker perceived supervisor support relative to fixed-desk arrangements [1], small and non-significant productivity effects alongside gains in perceived organisational support for activity [8], and falling productivity and satisfaction after relocation to a flexible office, particularly among staff whose work demands sustained concentration [9]—without typically auditing the accuracy of the signage meant to resolve who sits where day to day. Workspace satisfaction in a multi-space office correlates most strongly with social capital among co-workers rather than with the physical environment alone [10]. Wayfinding research treats

signage accuracy as one factor among several shaping successful navigation through an institutional building [11], and even where the great majority of visitors eventually reach a destination, most still resort to asking staff directly rather than relying on signage alone [12]. Workplace status, meanwhile, is now measurable independently of formal rank, letting researchers separate a person's perceived standing from their official title [13].

Prior audits within the University itself have found comparable drift between a physical count and its system of record [14] and between a certifying signature and the checklist it is meant to attest to [15]; this paper extends that line of audit to desk-level signage.

Method

Setting. Nine shared postdoctoral and early-career-fellow offices in the School of Continuous Improvement's building host four desks each (36 desks total), allocated weekly through the School's central booking calendar. Each desk carries a sliding-tab nameplate mounted on the corridor-facing wall beside the door; occupants are instructed, on booking or vacating a desk, to slide the tab to the incoming name or to blank.

Audit protocol. Every Monday between 08:50 and 09:20, for fourteen consecutive teaching weeks, two research assistants recorded the name displayed on each of the 36 tabs and cross-referenced it against that week's calendar entry, yielding 504 desk-week observations. A desk-week is coded as matched when the displayed name equals the booked occupant's name (or the tab is correctly blank for an unbooked desk) and mismatched otherwise. For each mismatched desk-week we additionally recorded the number of weeks since the calendar last changed occupant for that desk, as a measure of staleness:

$$\text{staleness}(d, w) = w - \text{last update week}(d)$$

where d indexes desks and w indexes the audit week.

Misdirection log. The building's front office maintains an informal intercept log of mail, parcels, and drop-in visitors it redirects once a name-based delivery or enquiry reaches the wrong desk. We extracted every intercept attributable to a specific desk across the fourteen

weeks (142 events) and matched each to that desk-week's audit record.

Occupant tier. Outgoing occupants were coded into two tiers from their canonical title: a senior tier (Associate Professor and above, or a named Convenorship) and a junior tier (Postdoctoral Fellow, Research Fellow without a Convenorship). Days-to-update was measured from the calendar's occupant-change date to the first Monday audit on which the tab reflected the new name.

Reminder ablation. From week 8 onward, a laminated card reading "Please update your desk tab when you swap desks" was mounted above each office's tab bank. Weeks 1–7 (pre) and weeks 9–14 (post, excluding the recovery week immediately following the mid-semester break) were compared on match rate; week 8 itself was excluded from both arms as a confounded transition week.

Results

Offices audited	9
Desks per office	4
Desk-weeks audited	504
Occupant changes observed	41
Misdirection events logged	142

Table 1: Audit sample overview.

Table 1 summarises the audit sample. Across the fourteen teaching weeks, the nameplate matched the booking calendar's rostered occupant in 358 of 504 desk-weeks audited (71.0%), with the remaining 146 desk-weeks (29.0%) showing a stale or incorrect tab.

Match rate over the semester is not flat. Figure 1 shows a marked dip in week 8, the first audit Monday after the mid-semester break, when only 14 of 36 desks (38.9%) carried a current tab; the rate recovers across the following two weeks before returning to its pre-break band. We interpret the dip as evidence that the tab lags any change concentrated around a calendar discontinuity rather than drifting at a constant background rate.

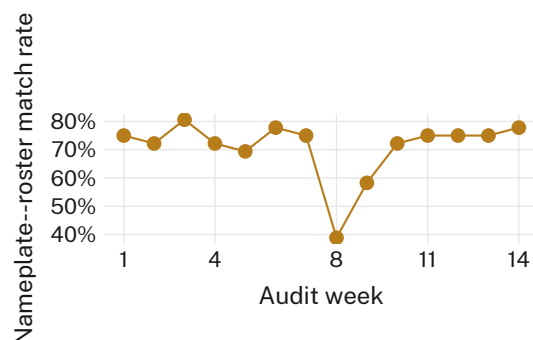


Figure 1: Nameplate-roster match rate across the fourteen-week audit; the week-8 dip follows the mid-semester break, and the reminder card goes up from week 8 onward.

The front office's intercept log recorded 142 misdirection events across the semester — mail items, parcels, and drop-in visitors redirected once a name-based delivery reached the wrong desk. Desk-weeks with a stale tab, though only 29.0% of the sample, accounted for 105 of these events (73.9%); the remaining 37 events occurred at desk-weeks where the tab was itself correct, a residual rate we attribute to courier and visitor error independent of the signage.

Occupant tier predicts how quickly a desk's tab is updated after a change. Across the semester's 41 recorded occupant changes (14 involving a senior-tier outgoing occupant, 27 a junior-tier one), senior-tier changes carried a median lag of 5 days before the tab reflected the new occupant (IQR 3–8), against a median of 1 day for junior-tier changes (IQR 0–3; Figure 2). A Mann-Whitney test on the update-lag distributions is significant at the semester's sample size ($p < 0.01$); we note the small n and do not generalise the effect size beyond this building.

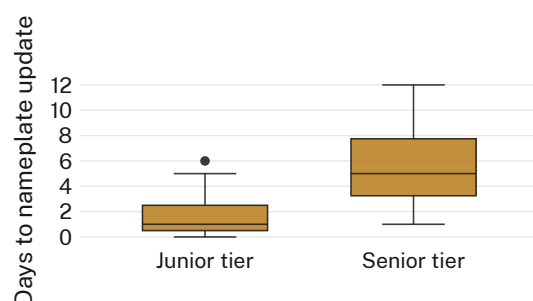


Figure 2: Days between an occupant change and the desk's tab reflecting it, by the outgoing occupant's title tier ($n = 41$ occupant changes); senior-tier occupants leave their name up markedly longer.

The reminder card, mounted from week 8 onward, leaves the match rate statistically unchanged: 74.6% across the seven pre-campaign weeks against 72.2% across the six clean post-campaign weeks (week 8 itself excluded as a confounded transition week; Figure 3), a difference well within the semester’s week-to-week noise.

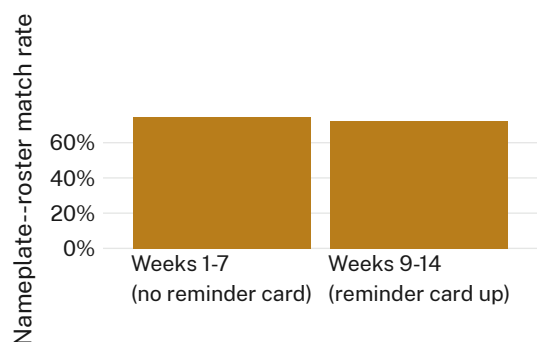


Figure 3: Nameplate-roster match rate before and after the reminder card went up; the card leaves the rate statistically unchanged, and we retain it as recommended signage.

The ablation’s null result sits alongside the tier effect above: if the tab were read purely as an informational field, a low-cost written reminder should have closed at least part of the gap. That it did not suggests the remaining quarter of desk-weeks reflects an equilibrium level of drift rather than an addressable backlog of forgetting.

Discussion

The picture across all three questions is consistent with a nameplate that functions locally as more than a directory field. The tab tracks the calendar closely most weeks, degrades sharply around a scheduling discontinuity, and recovers over roughly a fortnight without intervention — a pattern more consistent with occupants updating the tab when they next think to, rather than as a matter of course. That downstream misdirection concentrates so heavily in the stale desk-weeks suggests the front office is, in effect, running a live correction layer over a record the rest of the building treats as authoritative.

The tier effect is the more uncomfortable finding. A senior-tier occupant leaving their name up for a working week after handing back a desk reads less as an oversight than as a residual claim, consistent with territoriality accounts in

which a workspace marker persists after the entitlement to it has formally moved on [2], [4]. A reminder addressed at the informational gap did not move a behaviour that may not be informational; social-norm signage has moved comparable behaviour elsewhere only when the norm named is proximate to the setting rather than generic [16], [17], a specificity our card did not attempt. We suggest the School’s Adaptive Metrics Lab, whose own indicator-currency work has documented comparable drift elsewhere in the building, is well placed to pilot an automated tab rather than a laminated one. A stale nameplate is also, in a small way, a knowledge-loss problem: what the desk’s sign no longer knows about who occupies it is a version of what a team loses when a departing member’s informal record is never formally updated [18].

Limitations

Our audit covers one School’s shared offices over a single teaching semester; the 41 occupant changes observed limit the tier comparison’s precision, though the consistency of the direction across all fourteen weeks suggests the effect is not an artefact of any one busy fortnight. The misdirection log depends on front-office staff noticing and recording an intercept, which likely undercounts events resolved informally between neighbouring desks — if anything, this understates the concentration of error in stale desk-weeks rather than inflating it. The reminder ablation ran for six clean weeks only; a longer campaign was not available within the audit window, though the absence of any early movement in the post-campaign weeks of Figure 3 makes a delayed effect an unlikely explanation for the null result.

Conclusion

A shared office’s sliding-tab nameplate and its booking calendar agree most of the time, and disagree in a pattern — concentrated after scheduling discontinuities, slower to correct for senior-tier occupants, resistant to a written reminder — that looks more like a status marker than a directory error. The 73.9% of misdirected mail, parcels, and visitors traceable to a stale tab suggests the front office is already absorbing the cost of this gap without anyone having audited it. Future work should trial an automated, calendar-linked tab against the laminated-card baseline reported here, and extend the audit

to the University's other shared-office buildings to test whether the tier effect holds outside a School whose own research agenda is measurement.

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